

**Undo that thing you do**

Gmail has added an undo feature via Labs. The feature holds your email for 5 seconds before sending it off

First look at Windows Mobile 6.5

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Somewhere in mid-February, against the back drop of the World Mobile Congress, Microsoft unveiled its latest Windows Mobile version – the eagerly awaited version 6.5. Initial reports spoke of an all-new home screen (R.I.P. Today screen) and several UI improvements. The new OS also introduced an increased emphasis on being finger-friendly. But since then, there have been many mixed reactions. Here's a lowdown on some of the new features.

The honeycomb launcher

The start menu now comes in an attractive honeycomb format, which aims to minimise accidental tapping or fumbling around for what you want. This is also because this Honeycomb screen is completely customisable allowing you to have your favourite applications or links one tap away. The large icons also go a way to make the interface finger-friendly.

Each subsequent layer in the menu also follows the same format. Sure, a few existing users who are used to the older format will take a while to get used to it, but their number would be few, we imagine. This is definitely a step in the right direction. We feel that the UI designers should do something about the Close button though; reports say that one is still a pain to tap.

Home screen and new user interface

Zune's influence on the new home screen is undeniable and it's perfectly in line with WinMo's new philosophy of "people-centric" systems. This interface is designed to feed important information up front and create for a better navigation experience. Thus, items such as new emails, texts, missed calls and calendar appointments are fed to you right on the home/lock screen. You can swipe up and down through the items and left or right for more of each item. There is also the

option of being able to add web widgets for things such as weather. These widgets will automatically update, improving the information feed to you.

IE Mobile

With Windows Mobile 6.5 you'll get IE 6, which is based on the Internet Explorer 6 engine. The browser will support Flash and JavaScript. It also includes new tools for better page navigation, such as zoom in/out slider (see image) and a breadcrumb feature that shows you where you are on a web page. Through these changes, your browsing experience when viewing desktop-sized pages should definitely be better than with the older Pocket Internet Explorer.

If you are wondering why this OS still bundles a version 6 browser, when IE 8 is out, the answer is that the majority of websites were built to



the IE 6 standard. Web applications

One of the biggest inclusions on Windows Mobile 6.5 is the widget engine. This will allow applications built from HTML and JavaScript to run on a device, but without the address bar and other browser menus. A widget is simply a compressed collection of HTML, JavaScript, and image files that work together to perform a function. Companies offering web-based services can use this feature to create simple applications for the mobile OS. For example – widgets for auctions on eBay or news updates can be added to bring you updates on your mobile phone. Reports indicate that the current build will come pre-loaded with MSN Money, MSN Weather and a Live Search widget. Sure, Apple and even Nokia have this feature, but better late than never, right Microsoft?

My Phone

With its new My Phone application, Microsoft will offer a service to sync information with the cloud. My Phone is a backup and restore application that lives on the web and allows you to back up your phone's information online, while being password protected. With automatic

syncing and backup, you can store your contacts, appointments, text messages, and other information using the service and then easily restore the information to your device if you were to switch phones or worse, lose the one you have. It even allows you to upload videos and photos. The service is currently in beta and is invitation-only.

Windows Marketplace

Think of it as the App Store for Windows Mobile. Through Marketplace, users will have access to downloadable applications for their Windows phones. The new Marketplace will be included with all Windows phones based on Windows Mobile 6.5, and will allow users to browse, search and download applications. Developers who have already created programs for Windows Mobile will be able to offer their products through the Marketplace after a security and compatibility check from Microsoft.

Where are the phones?

Currently all phones which can support the new version of Windows Mobile are still being bundled with the older v.6.1, including the HTC Touch Pro2 and HTC Touch Diamond2. They will be upgraded to v.6.5 free of charge when the OS officially launches around September 2009. Incidentally, Microsoft has decided to call handsets based on their OS, "Windows Phones". The LG-GM7300 is one such example.

Windows Mobile 7

If this stuff doesn't impress you much, and there is little earth shattering anyway, more like baby steps, there is always the next version to look forward to. In fact, even Microsoft CEO Steve Ballmer admitted that Windows Mobile 6.5 might not make the OS a preferred choice for prosumers. Therefore the general consensus in the mobile world is that v.6.5 is Microsoft's first step towards a possibly market disruptive Windows Mobile 7. In fact, Microsoft has taken several steps to accelerate the team working on the next version. Still it looks like we won't catch a glimpse of Windows Mobile 7 until sometime in 2010.

